There’s a brief discussion about the flick of the fingers. The ball, he tells me, will start rotating backwards on its axis. His speech is concise and direct, as if he is gifting me the natural laws of the universe, and suddenly it all makes sense.

We briefly discuss the inswinger too, talking about the same technique but the feeling coming from the index finger instead, the ball pointing at leg slip. If you can master both of these, he says, you will be able to do something not many people have ever done.

I have the ball on a string during the second innings. There is no guessing, no running on the back of a strange energy like I’ve mounted a manic horse, but actual control. It goes exactly where I want it every time. It was true, it was all *feel*. Later that year, Mike will select me to open the bowling with Kyle Hogg in the first team. I was 17 and he was 19. My first wicket is Ian Ward, caught behind by Warren Hegg. I had landed in the perfect storm that season, where all my willing and wildness was met with a group of cricketers who knew exactly where to point it. Warren Hegg, captain and wicketkeeper of that team, would have periods when he told me not to worry at all about the field or anything, just bowl as fast as I could. Then Mike would be softly preaching the arts when I needed it, with other great seamers like Glen Chapple and Peter Martin always watching and helping. If it hadn’t been for them that year, I would have been happy just to run myself into a puppyish frenzy for a few years, taking wickets, bowling wides and going back to Burnley satisfied with a ragtag career in the County game.

The lifestyle at Lancashire and welcoming into County Cricket is like an awakening into an adult world, disarmingly everyday for one that requires actual athleticism. Gary Keedy is my roommate and, every morning without fail, the moment he wakes up, before he even opens his eyes, he fumbles around for a cigarette. I’m in the bed next door to him and become accustomed to my alarm being the smell of smoke. He wouldn’t even turn the light on, I would just wake to the orange glow of his first cigarette. Half of the team smoke and during practice or games, the first team congregate on the second team balcony to light up. Benson and Hedges are sponsoring the one-day tournament too and, with every round you progress, someone will turn up with a pack of duty-free, comedy-sized boxes of cigarettes. All the smokers get free rein, passing them around